strengthening so they could resist communism.[286] A working group considering large-scale, long-term economic assistance for Asia advised that neutral countries be included.[287] This was important given, as an intelligence estimated outlined, Chinese economic progress, especially on the industrial front.[288]

The NSC planning board proposed that in response the US should "develop the basic stability and strength of non-Communist countries, especially Japan and India."[289] The State Department and most other members of the board believed that since there was little prospect of reducing absolute Chinese power—as the Defense Department and the Joint Chiefs of Staff desired—by building up these other countries, they could reduce relative Chinese power.[290]

Not everyone on the NSC agreed that India was important. Treasury Secretary Humphrey argued that the US was better off focusing on building up Indonesia and Japan as counterbalances to China. Eisenhower disagreed: India's size and its "very good military material" made it significant, and if it fell to the communists, it might "cost us the entire Middle East" too. The US "could not afford to lose such great areas as India." Defense Secretary Wilson concurred, asserting "every effort should be made to hold" that country.[291] Dulles's special assistant for foreign aid separately noted that even Congress realized that Indian failure could "be disastrous to US security interests," which is why they eventually always appropriated some funds for it.[292]

By 1955, the Soviet economic offensive in the nonaligned world, military setbacks in Indochina, and increased India-Soviet engagement caused the re-emergence of American concern that the West was losing ground in India.[293] This led to discussions of an expanded foreign assistance program, which Eisenhower called "the cheapest insurance in the world."[294] And for the president, India had "special status."[295] Admitting that he did not trust Nehru, Eisenhower nonetheless told the head of a media conglomerate visiting Asia that spring, "Don't go slamming the Indians in any stories." After all, if that country was lost to communism, "the free world will be up against it, not only in the East but throughout the world … We have got to keep them at least on the neutral side if we can."[296] This echoed Acheson's remark that even though Nehru was "one of the most